Hoapa

Logic, collective inquiry and open-science workshops

Jean-Charles Belouard

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Introduction — The context

Pitch

The core of my research consists in drawing inspiration from the philosophy of mathematics and the engineering of networks to formulate a theory of work constrained by “permacultural” logic: how to produce reusable results while preserving the conditions for future work. Applied to collectives, it becomes an extension of the scientific method which incorporates participatory democracy and sustainability.

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- [...]: one point of view among many
- *Permacultural*: concretely minimal, abstractly demanding
- *Scientific method*:
  well-regulated scientist–Nature relation + (ad hoc peer review $\hookrightarrow$ universities $\hookrightarrow$ economy) $\rightarrow$ well-regulated network of relations among scientists, each retaining a well-regulated relation with Nature

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Introduction — The main thesis

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My main thesis states that in a system that puts the dialectic between concrete and abstract to work (brain, computer, community), the relation between concrete substrate and logical labor must be a resource entirely dedicated to the design and application of representations and algorithms. A form of separation between two kinds of decomposition—analytic (as in prime factorization) and synthetic (as in vector coordinates relative to a basis)—is a guiding principle, informed by Lautman, which can keep this relation fruitful: in a community, between thinkers and the knowledge they produce.

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- *Work*: explosion vs. engine, the role of constraints;
  engine vs. organism, the role of closure;
  engine vs. computer, the role of the "abstract loop"

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- *Dedicated*: in computers, in cells, in brains, in communities

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Theory of work

The physical starting point is that work depends on constraints that channel energy into particular effects. In living systems, activity also helps maintain the machinery that makes further activity possible. Abstract representations and algorithms enable a system to retain and share experience, discover relations, construct and test possibilities, revise its own means of understanding and action, and turn results into conditions for further work. This makes the relation between concrete conditions and abstract operations a powerful resource. Lautman supplies a way to investigate such relations through the mathematical and physical constructions that give them substance; Peirce, Simondon, and Kauffman help connect the question to living beings, their environments, and their practices of understanding. Hoapa's proposed separation between thinkers and the organization of knowledge is an engineering approach to developing this potential.

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Constraints: effects — *Maintain*: closure — *Abstract*: secondary loop

Project

Hoapa is an open project in mathematics, software, and the design of collective inquiry. I set its direction, develop its questions, and decide which proposals to pursue. AI agents help explore mathematical connections, compare approaches, and write and review code and documentation. Cubical Agda checks that the formalized constructions fit together under explicit definitions and assumptions, allowing new work to build on results already established.

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- *Results*: "Event-Local Sheafification and a Linear/Non-Linear Adjunction with Chu Coefficients"

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Hoapa is designed as a network of small conversations in which one group's work becomes another group's starting point. A question brings participants together; their discussion produces a document that others can examine, challenge, or develop. These documents form a growing map of questions, concepts, arguments, and dependencies: a knowledge graph. So that contributions can differ and come unforced, the system gives participants control and equal standing (they all play by the same rules they themselves manage). Knowledge acquires structure independently of the structure of its producers, be it social, political, economic…

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- *Independently*: respecting the concrete/abstract separation of concerns

Introduction — What is checked, what is conjectured

Verification

The communication protocols specify how these conversations proceed and how their results enter the shared documentation. Software is used as a referee and is itself subject to modification by the conversations. Alongside the conversation process, a mathematical verification layer is being developed in cubical Agda, a language in which proofs can be checked by a computer. One existing result establishes that consistently renaming participants cannot change the checker’s verdict. The broader aim is to make the system’s promises precise enough to test and prove.

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- *Referee*: automation as *liberation from control mechanisms*, from the necessity to have management
- *Verification*: machine-checks that the record of each conversation is well-formed, never that its conclusions are true
- *Renaming*: the protocol is blind to identity of contributors, which means it can't count on specialization (is knowledge lost?)

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Conjecture

The project seeks a mathematical correspondence—an adjunction—between two poles. One organizes inquiry through conversations, verification, and knowledge graphs. The other represents mathematical contexts and the different perspectives through which they can be investigated. The conjecture is guided by an intuition prompted by the perspectival nature of the world: our different understandings of it invite discussion, without presuppositions, from which something the world can reuse may emerge. The conjecture asks whether a universal property can distinguish Hoapa's organization from alternatives. This talk will explore a candidate in which methods are represented by logics and mathematical worlds by the inner models they generate.

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- *Universal property*: "specialness" vs. optimality

Permacultural logic

The project also looks for this pattern inside logic, where “permaculture” is understood broadly as the two-step process of (1) getting to know one’s context as much as possible, (2) acting minimally in a manner that will enhance one’s condition while preserving and enriching the context. A proof may begin with a provisional assumption (borrow), derive a conclusion (work), and turn the derivation into a conditional statement that later proofs can use (replay). What began as work under particular conditions becomes a reusable achievement. Hoapa investigates this borrow–work–replay pattern as a possible logical expression of its permacultural ambition: the harmony between receiving and giving back.

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- *Harmony*: as in Gentzen
- *Replay*: the hidden part of logic that makes logic work

Development

The architecture of a “mature” Hoapa system is both demanding—to respect its constraints—and—by virtue of presuppositionlessness—unpredictable. Autonomous open-science workshops could make these ideas tangible and seed larger systems, embracing both pragmaticism and experimentalism. Their first requirement is usefulness: knowledge sharing must be truly at stake, so that the organization develops through serving a real purpose. Concretely, I envision something based on the philosophy of “document driven development”, where documentation gradually replaces the instructor, both as the joint source of truth and the manager of the process.

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- *Unpredictable*: collective inquiry helps determine how collective inquiry is organized
- *Stake*: what distinguishes and makes citizen assemblies efficient; you can't simulate life or understanding
- *Documentation*: does in the Lautmanian-analytic what specialization does in the synthetic: shared source and management, but "softer"

Implementation — Use cases

A park

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Here it is crucial to understand that the system can preserve its advantageous mathematical, social and engineering properties if it is **only** a communication system, and not a full management system which also enacts in reality what has been discussed in the abstract.

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Its task is to chart the world and design appropriate algorithms, not interfere with and certainly not control it. (That would kill all the carefully crafted separations of concerns, starting with the role-symmetry of agents, because it necessarily introduces some hierarchical structure and tension—for basically the same reasons you can share an idea with the entire world without losing it, but you can't do that with a loaf of bread.)

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- *Role-symmetry*: rename the participants; preserve the verdict

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In either direction, we can think of Hoapa as a coach in sports: its domain of action is preparation and strategy, but it can never enter the field of play or control the players. The game belongs to the players.

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In this example, we can imagine an institution/Hoapa hybrid in which the city government has delegated the supervision of the park to the protocol, but it's still the paid workforce of gardeners which will perform the tasks suggested by the protocol. But ideally, in the spirit of the protocol, it would be only voluntary work, suggested by the protocol but decided at the level of the individuals and communities.

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Which makes Hoapa protocols especially well suited to organize the open source economy.

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The main recurring problem open source projects face is scalability and continuation beyond the circle of core contributors and maintainers, usually the instigators of the project: because open source projects are structured around “circles of knowledge and influence”, which is in essence a hierarchy, it is very likely to terminate the moment the inner circle quits.

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The same arguments can be used to suggest a reform of how science is conducted.

Implementation — Use cases

Science

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While the scientific method, in the domains where it is applicable, makes claims answerable to evidence and correction, it doesn't prevent other types of evils. Notably a mismanagement of efforts toward certain technologies at the expense of understanding, the fragmentation of the study of Nature into opposing departments, the proliferation of opaque jargons, the insistence that there exists a "view from nowhere", the enclosure of knowledge behind paywalls, proprietary tools, and restricted access, the depreciation of errors and failures, etc.

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- *Language*: "Learn once, write everywhere" ← a shared conceptual landscape built through explicit and systematic comparisons (interpretation, equivalence, coherence, ...)

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And the organization of inquiry is itself something we can try to understand mathematically.

Implementation — Use cases

Mathematics

All of the above applies in mathematics as well, but here the connection goes further: mathematics also supplies the language in which the organization of mathematical work can itself be investigated. Hoapa's formalization uses Cubical Agda, bringing together homotopy type theory, computer-checked proofs, and a line of thought connecting Grothendieck's ideas about homotopy types and higher groupoids with Vladimir Voevodsky's univalent foundations.*

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Grothendieck also questioned the ecological consequences of scientific activity; Hoapa approaches that concern by asking how understanding a world can help us inhabit it.